

a long boat ride” and he responded “Tell me about boats”, one wouldn’t assume that he knew nothing about boats, but that he had some purpose in so directing the subsequent conversation. It’s important to note that this assumption is one made by the speaker.

Thus, ELIZA the psychiatric chatbot was born. And in initial tests, it performed magnificently. Here’s an excerpt from a conversation between ELIZA and a real human:

Human: Men are all alike.

ELIZA: In what way?

Human: They’re always bugging us about something or other.

ELIZA: Can you think of a specific example?

Human: Well, my boyfriend made me come here.

ELIZA: Your boyfriend made you come here

Human: He says I’m depressed much of the time.

ELIZA: I am sorry to hear you are depressed

Human: It’s true. I am unhappy

ELIZA: Do you think coming here will help you not to be unhappy

Human: I need some help, that much seems certain.

ELIZA: What would it mean to you if you got some help

Human: Perhaps I could learn to get along with my mother.

ELIZA: Tell me more about your family

Human: My mother takes care of me.

ELIZA: Who else in your family takes care of you

Human: My father.

ELIZA: Your father

Human: You are like my father in some ways.

ELIZA: What resemblance do you see

Human: You are not very aggressive but I think you don’t want me to notice that.

ELIZA: What makes you think i am not very aggressive

Human: You don’t argue with me.

ELIZA: Why do you think i don’t argue with you

Human: You are afraid of me.

ELIZA: Does it please you to believe i am afraid of you

Human: My father is afraid of everybody.

ELIZA: What else comes to your mind when you think of your father

Human: Bullies.